

Employee Leave and Absence Policy

1. Purpose and Scope

This Leave Policy sets out the entitlements, procedures, and conditions for all categories of employee absence. It applies to all permanent employees of the organisation. The company recognises the importance of a healthy work-life balance and is committed to administering leave entitlements fairly and consistently. All leave requests must be submitted through the HR system and are subject to the approval process described in this policy.

2. Types of Leave and Annual Entitlements

Annual Vacation Leave: All permanent employees are entitled to 20 working days of paid vacation leave per calendar year. Vacation leave must be scheduled in advance wherever possible and is subject to manager approval for requests of 4 days or more.

Sick Leave: Employees are entitled to 10 days of paid sick leave per calendar year. Sick leave may only be taken when an employee is genuinely unwell. A medical certificate may be required for absences exceeding 3 consecutive sick days.

Personal Leave: Employees are entitled to 5 days of paid personal leave per calendar year for personal matters that cannot be scheduled outside working hours.

Maternity Leave: Eligible employees are entitled to up to 26 weeks of maternity leave. The first 6 weeks are paid at full salary; the remaining 20 weeks are at statutory pay rates. Employees must provide at least 8 weeks notice of their expected start date.

Paternity Leave: Eligible employees are entitled to 2 weeks of paternity leave at full pay, to be taken within 8 weeks of the child's birth or adoption placement.

Bereavement Leave: 5 days paid leave for the death of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, or sibling); 3 days for other close relatives.

3. Notice Requirements and Auto-Approval Rules

Minimum Advance Notice: All leave requests must be submitted at least 3 working days in advance. Requests submitted with less than 3 working days notice may still be considered but will require manager approval regardless of duration.

Auto-Approval: Leave requests of 3 working days or fewer will be automatically approved by the system provided all of the following conditions are met: the employee has sufficient leave balance remaining for the requested leave type, there are no conflicts with existing approved leave requests, there are no conflicts with company blackout periods, and the request meets the 3-day minimum advance notice requirement.

Manager Approval: Leave requests of 4 to 14 working days require manager approval. Requests with short notice but otherwise valid will also be escalated to the manager. The manager must respond within 2 working days of receiving the approval request.

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4. Maximum Consecutive Days and Blackout Periods

Maximum Consecutive Days: Employees may not take more than 14 consecutive working days of leave without explicit approval from their line manager and HR. Requests exceeding 14 consecutive working days will be escalated for approval regardless of other conditions.

Blackout Periods: The company designates certain dates as blackout periods during which leave requests will not be approved due to business-critical demands such as year-end financial closing, major product launches, or peak operational periods. Blackout period dates are communicated to employees at least 6 weeks in advance. Leave requested that overlaps with a blackout period is automatically rejected. Exceptions require written approval from a department head and HR.

5. Leave Balances, Deductions, and Carry-Forward

Insufficient Balance: If an employee requests leave for which they have insufficient balance remaining, the request will be automatically rejected. Employees may not take leave in advance of their accrued entitlement without prior written approval from HR.

Unpaid Leave: If an employee exhausts their leave balance and requires additional time off, unpaid leave may be approved at the manager's and HR's discretion. Unpaid leave days result in a proportional salary deduction calculated as the daily rate multiplied by the number of unpaid leave days taken in the pay period.

Annual Carry-Forward: Unused vacation leave of up to 5 days may be carried forward to the following calendar year and must be used before the end of March. Any carry-forward leave unused by that date will be forfeited. Sick leave and personal leave do not carry forward to the following year.